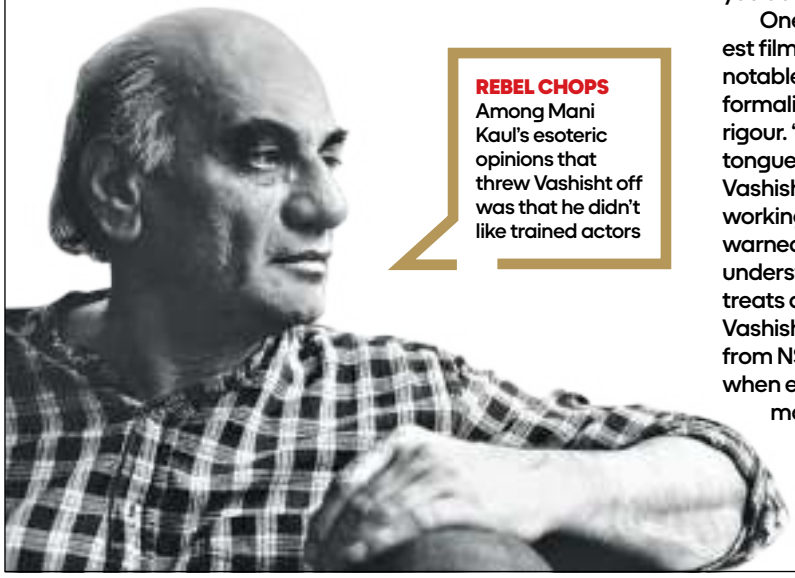
CINEMA ▼

The Colour Of Acting

MITA VASHISHT'S DOCUMENTARY ON THE LATE FILMMAKER **MANI KAUL** DEFIES CLASSIFICATION

The colourist for Mita Vashisht's film *Mani Kaul and That Thing Called The Actor* had been trained to colour-correct films based on genre; noir would be darker, rom-coms sunnier. When he asked Vashisht what the genre of her film was, the esteemed actor-turned-filmmaker had no answer.

"My film is not a conventional documentary with talking heads," says Vashisht. "It is like a poem. It is an exploration of Mani Kaul's ideas on acting, which I discovered when I starred in the lead role of Hindustani classical singer Siddheshwari Devi in his film *Siddheshwari*. Like Mani, a master of cinematic language, who composed his frames himself, I, too, got the colours and frames I wanted during the making itself. So, I had to tell the colourist, just watch the film, you don't have to do much."



REBEL CHOPS
Among Mani Kaul's esoteric opinions that threw Vashisht off was that he didn't like trained actors

One of India's greatest filmmakers, Kaul was notable for his attention to formalism and aesthetic rigour. "The title is, of course, tongue-in-cheek," explains Vashisht. "When I began working with Mani, I was warned that he does not understand acting, he treats actors as objects." Vashisht had just graduated from NSD in the early 1990s, when experimental filmmaker Kumar Shahani directed her in a short film *Var Var Vari*. Kaul saw the film and exclaimed that she had the "screen presence of Nargis", recalls Vashisht. Kaul immediately cast her in *Siddheshwari*.

Among the esoteric director's first statements that threw Vashisht off was that he did not like trained actors. "Here I was, straight out of NSD, trained on everything from *Natyashastra* to Stanislavski," says Vashisht. "Actors are trained to underline and indicate emotions. Mani told me to capture Siddheshwari's being from within my body."

During *Siddheshwari*'s making, the English postgrad made copious notes on Kaul's techniques. For 30 years, these notes remained with her until she decided to turn them into a script around 2012. Over 12 years since, Vasisht shot the film with cinematographer Omar Adam Khan in Delhi, Mumbai, Varanasi and Rajasthan. Lapdiang Syiem plays an actress working in a Mani Kaul project in Vashisht's self-referential project. Dhrupad musician Arman Ali Dehlvi is her co-star.

"How do I describe my film?" Vashisht hunts for the right words. "You have to watch it to understand it."■

—Devarsi Ghosh

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Still at the Movies

The latest edition of IFFM will screen over 75 films in 30 languages, including India's first LGBTQIA+ film

The Indian Film Festival of Melbourne (IFFM) will return for its 16th edition from August 14-24. Positioned as the largest celebration of Indian cinema outside the country, it promises insightful masterclasses, poignant films and star-studded red carpet moments.

A key highlight of this edition is the screening of the 1971 film, *Badnam Basti*. Directed by Prem Kapoor and based on Kamleshwar's debut novel, *Ek Sadak Sattavan Galiyan*, the film is widely regarded as India's first film to depict a same-sex relationship. Also screening is Onir's latest film, *We Are Faheem and Karun*, that explores forbidden romance in a remote Kashmiri village. "Cinema holds the extraordinary power to bridge divides and spark meaningful dialogue. Our Pride Night is both a celebration and a reclamation—of space, of history, and of visibility for LGBTQIA+ voices in Indian cinema," says festival director Mitu Bhowmick Lange.



A still from Onir's *We Are Faheem and Karun*, about a forbidden romance in a remote Kashmiri village

The festival's slate includes Tillotama Shome's Bengali drama *Baksho Bondi*, Rima Das's Village *Rockstars 2* and Lakshmipriya Devi's Asia Pacific Screen Award-winning *Boong*.■

—Karishma Upadhyay